

Participant Guide

Primary Education Online

This guide is yours. It holds a short summary of each online session and every activity you will work on across the series. Type in the Word version on screen, or print it and write by hand.

Name (optional)

School

Welcome

Across four online sessions you will build a broad, mixed picture of Autistic experience, then turn it into one practical change in your classroom and one purposeful conversation with a family or student.

Taking part online

- Cameras are optional. Turn yours on or off as you need.
- Chat, reactions, speaking, private notes or passing all count as taking part.
- Some activities use small breakout rooms. You can ask to stay in the main room.
- Move, stretch or step away and come back whenever you need to.

How to use this guide

- Each session opens with a one-page summary of the key ideas. Activity pages follow, ready to write on.
- Keep two or three real students in mind across the series. Choose students who differ from each other.
- Use initials or roles only, in this guide, in the chat and in breakout rooms.

The series at a glance

Length	Session	
60 minutes	1	Lens and Autistic Experience
60 minutes	2	Communication, Connection and the Primary School Day
60 minutes	3	Designing for Access in the Primary Classroom
60 minutes	4	Partnership, Flourishing and Next Steps

The thread through the series

The sessions run on separate days. A few pages carry forward from one session to the next:

Session 1	Think about your students, and a noticing task before Session 2
Session 2	Primary school-day map and Carry into design
Session 3	My brief, My design, My students check and Commit
Session 4	Bridge, Start · Continue · Reconsider, the conversation plan and the final reflection

Missed a session? Read that session's key ideas page and fill in what you can of its activity pages. At the next session, the facilitator will help you catch up with a partner.

Lens and Autistic Experience

Key ideas

A neurodiversity-affirming approach

Neurodiversity is the whole picture. Autism is one expression of that diversity. Differences are not deficits; all people have strengths and experience challenges; there is no right or wrong way to think, learn or behave.

The social model and dynamic disability

Use an environment-first lens: look for barriers in places, tasks, routines and expectations, and ask what can change around the student. A student's access and support needs may change with the task, environment, relationships and available capacity.

Sensory processing

There are eight senses, not five: touch, vision, taste, hearing and smell, plus proprioception (body in space), vestibular (balance and movement) and interoception (internal body signals). Sensory experience can include pleasure, connection and regulation as well as discomfort or overload. Recognise stimming as authentic expression.

Autistic thinking

- Detail-first processing: noticing details before building the whole picture, with real strengths in pattern recognition and precision.
- Deep focus (monotropism): attention channelled fully into fewer things; shifting attention takes time and warning.
- Executive functioning: planning, organisation, time management, working memory, meta-cognition, emotional regulation, flexibility, attention, task initiation and persistence.

Internal signals

Interoception is noticing and interpreting body signals. Alexithymia is difficulty identifying and describing emotions. Internal experience may not be visible.

ACTIVITY**Think about your students** On your own · private

Bring two or three students to mind, ideally students who are quite different from each other. You will return to them across the series.

Student	Strengths, interests or moments of connection that should stay visible
Student A	
Student B	
Student C	

Use initials or roles only. No names or identifying details.

What are you here for?	What would you like to understand better? You will look back at this in Session 4

ACTIVITY**What did you notice?** After the student voice video

What stayed with you?	What would you like to understand more deeply?

ACTIVITY**Strengths I can see** On your own

Detail-first thinking produces genuine strengths. What strengths do you see in the students you have in mind, and where do they show up?

Student	Strengths I have seen	Where or when I see them
Student A		
Student B		
Student C		

ACTIVITY**Sensory activity** Breakout rooms or on your own

Choose one familiar classroom routine. What sensory demands does the environment or task create, and what options could increase access or choice?

Routine:

Sensory demand (environment or task)	Option that could increase access or choice	Question to explore
1		
2		
3		

Notice one familiar routine with the students you have in mind. Bring your notes to Online Session 2.

What supports them

What helps access, connection or joy in that routine?

What adds demand

What seems to make it harder, and when?

What I do not know yet

Write it down as a question to explore.

Communication, Connection and the Primary School Day

Key ideas

Communication is multimodal

Speech is one part of communication. How much someone speaks does not tell us how much they understand. AAC (augmentative and alternative communication) is part of communication access. Clear communication, processing time and visual supports help; the right support depends on the person and the moment.

Double empathy and connection

Misunderstanding can happen in both directions between people with different experiences and communication styles. Connection does not need to look one way, and can happen with family, at school, in the community and online.

Managing daily capacity

Think of a student's energy as a battery, or a set of spoons. Every day starts with a different charge; every action uses some; the right supports can recharge it. A moment that seems small may sit within many demands across the day.

Masking, identity and belonging

What is visible does not tell the whole story. A student may be working hard to appear "fine". A child who knows who they are, and feels genuinely valued for it, has more available for everything else.

When do the students you have in mind seem most comfortable connecting with others at school?

What kinds of connection does each of them enjoy? (Talking, gaming, sport, making things, shared interests, being together quietly, online interaction?)

Are there times in the school day when being social seems enjoyable, and times when it seems tiring or overwhelming?

What can educators change to make social connection feel safer, easier or more meaningful?

Map a typical day in your classroom, from arrival to departure. Then mark how the same moments land for each of the students you have in mind.

Mark: R routine or transition C change T communication opportunity P moment to choose, pause or recover

Moment	What happens	Student A	Student B	Student C
Arrival				
Recess				
Lunch				
Departure				

The map is a working picture to extend, not a judgement of the student or school.

Costs

What adds demand or uncertainty?

Lightens

What reduces demand? What restores capacity or brings joy?

Where is a student's experience unknown?

When might one of the students you have in mind be working hard to appear "fine" at school when they are not?

When and where at school do they seem most comfortable being themselves?

What could we change to help them feel more comfortable and supported?

Choose from your day map.

Keep

One rhythm to keep because it supports access, connection or joy

Reduce Bring this to Session 3

One barrier or unnecessary demand to reduce

It is a: ☐ rotation ☐ transition ☐ whole-class routine

Explore

One question to explore with students, families or the team

Designing for Access in the Primary Classroom

Key ideas

Students come first

Move from understanding to design without turning students into a list of problems. Start with the real students you have in mind, a specific access question and evidence from your day map.

Design the change, then check it

This session designs one change to a rotation, a transition or a whole-class routine. You design it universally first, then check it against each of your students.

Options to draw on

- Executive functioning supports: match support to a known demand.
- Predictability: clear information about routine and change. Predictability is access to information, not a promise that nothing will change.
- Schedules: make sequence, timing and change visible.
- Visual supports: clarify what students need to find, understand, remember or communicate.

Universal first, then the continuum

Universal Design for Learning offers more than one way to access, engage and respond. Where a design still doesn't work for someone, support continues along a continuum: inclusive environment, universal supports, targeted supports, then individual adjustments, recorded through NCCD processes and levels of adjustment.

ACTIVITY**My brief** On your own

My routine:

It is a: ☐ rotation ☐ transition ☐ whole-class routine

This routine asks students to...

For some students, that means...

We could change...

☐ Specific, workable, and free from blame or deficit labels

ACTIVITY**Options I chose** After the inputs

- ☐ Executive functioning supports
- ☐ Predictability
- ☐ Schedules
- ☐ Visual supports
- ☐ Something else

Why it fits: which demand in my brief does it answer?

ACTIVITY**Accessibility check** Run these over your draft

- ☐ Can students find and understand what they need?
- ☐ Can they take part in more than one way?
- ☐ Can they pause, ask for help or recover?
- ☐ Is the support available when demand increases?

What I adjusted:

ACTIVITY**Quick review of a visual support** If your design uses one

- ☐ Can the student understand it?
- ☐ Can they access it when they need it?
- ☐ Does it reflect what is actually happening, including change?
- ☐ Does it provide useful information or a way to respond?

1 The barrier or unnecessary demand

2 The change to the environment, task or routine

3 How students' communication and experience are included

4 What I will observe

5 When I will review it

☐ Checked in a breakout pair: still student-centred and environment-first

ACTIVITY**My students check** On your own · private

Hold your design up against each of the students you have in mind.

	Helps	No difference	Needs something more
Student A			
Student B			
Student C			

Where the design still doesn't work for someone, that is where targeted or individual support begins.

ACTIVITY**Commit** Before you leave

What I will try	What I will notice	Who I will involve

Partnership, Flourishing and Next Steps

Key ideas

Where partnerships converge

Students, families, school staff and paraprofessionals each bring different knowledge and a different relationship with the student. The student is at the centre of every partnership.

Power dynamics

Power can sit in socio-economic status, historical and cultural experiences of education, language, understanding of school systems, and the perceived importance of school. It is also present in meeting structures, language and decision pathways.

Consultation literacy

Useful consultation has a clear shared purpose, open questions, more than one way to contribute, respect for student and family knowledge, accurate recording and an agreed action with follow-up. Ask, listen, and follow up.

When student capacity runs out

Meltdown, shutdown and School Can't are discussed without blame. Home and school may observe different parts of the student's experience. Focus on safety, what preceded the situation, what supports recovery and what can change.

Belonging, capacity and joy

Belonging: being recognised, included and able to participate as oneself. Capacity: what the day costs, protects and restores. Joy: interests, connection and authentic expression. Return to these when judging whether a change supports flourishing.

ACTIVITY**Power dynamics** Chat, whiteboard or private notes

An imbalance from a home perspective	An imbalance from a school perspective	How I could address these imbalances

ACTIVITY**Student voice** After the video

What decisions were made, and who made them?	What impact did those decisions have on Adon?	How are the students I have in mind asked and heard?

ACTIVITY**Consultation checklist** For your next meeting

- ☐ A clear, shared purpose
- ☐ Open questions
- ☐ More than one way to contribute
- ☐ Respect for student and family knowledge
- ☐ Accurate recording of what was heard
- ☐ An agreed action, responsibility and follow-up

ACTIVITY**Bridge to the next family conversation** On your own

Prepare for one purposeful conversation.

What needs to be understood?

What question will open the conversation?

How will the student's voice be included?

What can be decided together?

How and when will the school follow up?

Start

One strategy to start, something small you can start next week

Continue

One practice to continue, something this series confirmed you already do well

Reconsider

One approach to reconsider, something you would now do differently

How will I know it worked?	What evidence will show it?

This plan is yours. Your Session 3 commitment can be your Start.

Choose the real conversation you'll have within two weeks, with a student's family or with the student themselves.

What I'll share A strength first	What I'll ask Specifically	What I'll offer

My opening sentence, word for word

When	Where	How

Turn back to "Think about your students" in Session 1. Read your own words. What's different now?

Where was I at the start of Session 1?	Where am I now?

What will I do differently in my teaching?

Answer it in one sentence, for yourself.

Connections that continue

This series is a starting point. These supports continue after it.

Webinars and deep dives	Follow-ups on UDL, executive functioning, sensory design, anxiety and more. [Titles, dates and links to confirm]
Online Community of Practice	A place to keep talking with other educators after this series. [Link or QR code to add]
Positive Partnerships	positivepartnerships.com.au
Visual Supports Checklist	A practical resource for reviewing an existing support or planning a new one. [Where to find it, to confirm]
NCCD	NCCD Meetings Tool Kit and current official NCCD information: nccd.edu.au
Disability Standards for Education	Getting started; Advocating with and for your child; Milestones and transitions (Department of Education)
Autism Connect	National autism helpline: 1300 308 699
Disability Gateway	1800 643 787
Carer Gateway	Emotional, practical and financial support for carers: 1800 422 737

My notes
